Those Sikhs, especially of the younger generation, who had to stay outside Punjab for one reason or the other, sought safety in becoming clean-shaven as they had observed or heard that both in Haryana in November 1982 during Asian Games and the anti-Sikh pogrom of 1984, it was the turban over the head of a Sikh and not the Sikh per se, which was under attack. Gradually it became a matter of convenience amongst the Sikh youth and the young Sikh mothers found it extremely difficult to raise, train and maintain a turbaned Sikh young boy in the family.

The Pakistani agenda

Pakistan had been smarting from the loss of its eastern wing ever since Bangladesh emerged as an independent nation in December 1971 with India's help. In my view, the turmoil in Punjab, set in motion by the activities of the 1 Akbar Road group, was the greatest gift India could have given to Pakistan, which it has continued to relish until today. The Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) had always been meddling in the affairs of Punjab. But until the early 1980s this meddling was limited to small-scale operations like smuggling and intelligence collection, mainly because of an unreceptive population.

The activities of the 1 Akbar Road group created fertile ground for the ISI to make deeper inroads in Punjab, and they took full advantage of this situation. They organized training for the disgruntled young Sikh extremists by taking them across the border, or even by supplying them with the latest arms, including AK-47 rifles, within Punjab. It was generally believed by knowledgeable observers at that time that some of the killings in Punjab in the first half of the 1980s were directly or indirectly carried out by ISI-backed militants. And their interference continued for a long time after that.

Operation Blue Star and the anti-Sikh pogrom of November 1984 helped Pakistan carry forward its two-pronged agenda, planned by the wily (Jalandhar-born and St. Stephen's College-educated) President (1978–1988) Muhammad Zia-ul-Haq. In pursuit of that policy, throughout the 1980s and even later, Pakistan